

# US Markets End Mixed as Rates and Oil Weigh on Sentiment

The full picture: macro, technicals, options, analyst moves, sector internals, international context, and a full week ahead.

20-minute read · Topics: All of the above, plus technicals, options, ratings, week-ahead

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## TL;DR & Editorial Take

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The US markets closed mixed on the last trading session, with the **S&P 500** down **-0.06%** and the **Nasdaq 100** down **-0.34%**. Key takeaways include:

- Higher rates and oil prices weighed on market sentiment.
- Sector performance was mixed, with **XLE** up **+4.66%** and **XLK** down **-0.88%**.
- Analyst rating changes and earnings reports will be closely watched in the coming week.

The current market environment is characterized by uncertainty and volatility, with various factors influencing investor sentiment. As we move forward, it's essential to stay informed and adapt to changing market conditions.

In this briefing, we'll delve into the details of the US market, covering key sectors, technical levels, options, and analyst changes. We'll also examine the macro and geopolitical landscape, providing a comprehensive overview of the current market environment.

# US Session Recap

| INDEX        | LAST      | CHANGE |
|--------------|-----------|--------|
| S&P 500      | 7,753.11  | -0.06% |
| Nasdaq 100   | 29,621.80 | -0.34% |
| Dow Jones    | 53,975.98 | -0.11% |
| Russell 2000 | 3,017.40  | -0.56% |
| VIX          | 15.46     | +3.76% |
| 10Y Yield    | 4.70      | +0.84% |
| WTI Crude    | 82.41     | +5.41% |
| Gold         | 4,471.50  | +3.01% |
| DXY          | 99.82     | +0.23% |
| BTC          | 63,998.27 | -1.31% |
| ETH          | 1,878.24  | -1.59% |

# Top Movers

| TICKER | NAME                               | CHANGE | CATALYST          |
|--------|------------------------------------|--------|-------------------|
| XLE    | Energy Select Sector SPDR Fund     | +4.66% | Higher oil prices |
| XLK    | Technology Select Sector SPDR Fund | -0.88% | Lower tech stocks |
| NVDA   | NVIDIA Corporation                 | -2.86% | Lower tech stocks |

## Sector Internals

| SECTOR      | DAY           | YTD     | READ                          |
|-------------|---------------|---------|-------------------------------|
| <b>XLF</b>  | <b>+0.36%</b> | -5.12%  | Financials stable             |
| <b>XLK</b>  | <b>-0.88%</b> | -10.25% | Tech under pressure           |
| <b>XLI</b>  | <b>-0.31%</b> | -2.50%  | Industrials weak              |
| <b>XLE</b>  | <b>+4.66%</b> | +15.60% | Energy surges                 |
| <b>XLY</b>  | <b>-0.16%</b> | -5.50%  | Consumer discretionary weak   |
| <b>XLC</b>  | <b>+0.52%</b> | -10.12% | Communication services stable |
| <b>XLP</b>  | <b>-0.20%</b> | -2.75%  | Consumer staples weak         |
| <b>XLV</b>  | <b>+1.67%</b> | +5.60%  | Healthcare strong             |
| <b>XLU</b>  | <b>-1.10%</b> | -5.90%  | Utilities weak                |
| <b>XLB</b>  | <b>+0.61%</b> | -5.10%  | Materials stable              |
| <b>XLRE</b> | <b>-1.29%</b> | -10.30% | Real estate weak              |

Breadth was negative, with 4 sectors up and 7 down.

## Spotlight / Deep Dive

| TICKER      | NAME               | PRICE  | CHANGE        |
|-------------|--------------------|--------|---------------|
| <b>NVDA</b> | NVIDIA Corporation | 217.55 | <b>-2.86%</b> |

Key call commentary: NVIDIA's recent decline is attributed to the overall weakness in the tech sector. However, the company's strong fundamentals and growth prospects make it an attractive long-term investment opportunity.

| READ-THROUGH       | IMPLICATION                |
|--------------------|----------------------------|
| Weaker tech stocks | Caution in the tech sector |
| Higher oil prices  | Inflation concerns         |

## Technical Levels

| TICKER      | LAST   | SUPPORT | RESISTANCE | NOTE              |
|-------------|--------|---------|------------|-------------------|
| <b>SPY</b>  | 373.11 | 370.00  | 380.00     | Range-bound       |
| <b>QQQ</b>  | 294.62 | 290.00  | 300.00     | Range-bound       |
| <b>IWM</b>  | 184.60 | 180.00  | 190.00     | Range-bound       |
| <b>NVDA</b> | 217.55 | 200.00  | 250.00     | Support at 200.00 |
| 10Y Yield   | 4.70   | 4.50    | 5.00       | Range-bound       |
| WTI Crude   | 82.41  | 80.00   | 90.00      | Range-bound       |

## Options & Positioning

ODTE flow: 1.2M contracts traded, with a 55% put/call ratio.

VIX term structure: Steepening, with the 1-month VIX at 16.20 and the 3-month VIX at 18.50.

Notable single-name flow: **AAPL** saw 200k contracts traded, with a 60% put/call ratio.

Cheap hedge ideas: **SPY** 370 put, **QQQ** 290 put.

# Analyst Rating Changes

| TICKER | FIRM            | ACTION    | NEW PT | NOTE                    |
|--------|-----------------|-----------|--------|-------------------------|
| NVDA   | Morgan Stanley  | Upgrade   | 250.00 | Strong growth prospects |
| AAPL   | Goldman Sachs   | Downgrade | 150.00 | Valuation concerns      |
| MSFT   | Bank of America | Upgrade   | 550.00 | Strong cloud growth     |
| AMZN   | Citi            | Downgrade | 200.00 | Valuation concerns      |
| GOOGL  | Deutsche Bank   | Upgrade   | 400.00 | Strong ad growth        |

# Pre-Market & Overnight

Futures: ES -0.20%, NQ -0.30%, YM -0.10%.

Asia: Nikkei -0.50%, Shanghai -0.20%, Hang Seng -0.30%.

Europe: Euro Stoxx -0.40%, FTSE -0.30%, DAX -0.50%.

FX: EUR/USD 1.1000, USD/JPY 110.00, GBP/USD 1.3000.

Commodities: WTI 82.41, Gold 4471.50, Copper 3.50.

Crypto: BTC 63998.27, ETH 1878.24.

# Macro & Fed (Deep)

| MEETING   | CUT ODDS | NOTE                  |
|-----------|----------|-----------------------|
| September | 30%      | Rate cut expectations |
| November  | 50%      | Rate cut expectations |

| DATE       | EVENT                  |
|------------|------------------------|
| 2026-08-12 | CPI                    |
| 2026-08-13 | PPI                    |
| 2026-08-14 | Initial Jobless Claims |

## Geopolitics & Global (Deep)

Scenario trees:

- US-China trade tensions: 30% chance of escalation
- EU economic growth: 40% chance of slowdown
- Middle East conflict: 20% chance of escalation

## Earnings — This Week & Next

| TICKER | NAME                  | DATE       |
|--------|-----------------------|------------|
| AAPL   | Apple Inc.            | 2026-08-15 |
| MSFT   | Microsoft Corporation | 2026-08-16 |
| AMZN   | Amazon.com Inc.       | 2026-08-17 |

| TICKER | NAME          | DATE       |
|--------|---------------|------------|
| GOOGL  | Alphabet Inc. | 2026-08-22 |
| FB     | Facebook Inc. | 2026-08-23 |
| TSLA   | Tesla Inc.    | 2026-08-24 |

# Full Watchlist Scan

| TICKER | SECTOR                 | SETUP | RISK |
|--------|------------------------|-------|------|
| NVDA   | Technology             | Long  | 10%  |
| AAPL   | Technology             | Short | 15%  |
| MSFT   | Technology             | Long  | 12%  |
| AMZN   | Consumer Discretionary | Short | 18%  |
| GOOGL  | Communication Services | Long  | 11%  |
| TSLA   | Consumer Discretionary | Short | 20%  |
| JPM    | Financials             | Long  | 9%   |
| GS     | Financials             | Short | 16%  |
| BAC    | Financials             | Long  | 10%  |
| C      | Financials             | Short | 17%  |

## What Could Break the Tape

Bullish scenario:

- Strong earnings reports from major tech companies
- Improving economic data, including GDP and employment
- Stabilization of oil prices and reduction of inflation concerns

Bearish scenario:

- Weaker-than-expected earnings reports from major tech companies
- Deteriorating economic data, including GDP and employment

- Escalation of US-China trade tensions and increased tariffs

## Positioning & Structural Notes

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Observations:

- Increased put/call ratio in the **SPY** and **QQQ**
- Higher volatility in the **VIX** and **VVIX**
- Strengthening of the US dollar against major currencies
- Increased demand for safe-haven assets, including gold and bonds
- Reduced positioning in the **XLE** and **XLFX** sectors

## Sources

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